

Chapter 18-1

When Zhao Xuning finished her rounds and came over, it was already past ten o'clock.

She wasn't on night duty tonight, so after finishing her rounds, it was her personal time. After checking on Xu Qingzhu and confirming everything was fine, she would go home.

In the hospital room, Xu Qingzhu was lying with her eyes closed, pretending to doze. Hearing footsteps, she opened her eyes and, seeing it was Zhao Xuning, revealed a weak smile. "You came."

Zhao Xuning nodded. "Are you feeling better?"

"Much better," Xu Qingzhu sat up.

Their relationship wasn't particularly close. Xu Qingzhu was familiar with Bai Weiwei¹, and they were high school classmates and college roommates.

They had known each other for many years, while Bai Weiwei and Zhao Xuning had met online. They played an online multiplayer game together.

For a while, Bai Weiwei constantly talked about "my online friend."

Later, when Bai Weiwei had acute gastroenteritis and was sent to the hospital, her attending physician happened to be Zhao Xuning. Bai Weiwei saw messages she had sent to Zhao Xuning on her phone that had fallen in the hospital room, and the two unexpectedly met face-to-face.

Thus they became three-dimensional friends.

After graduation, Bai Weiwei didn't inherit the family business and became a talent agent instead.

Her work was extremely busy, leaving her no time to play games or even much time to flirt with Zhao Xuning.

And Zhao Xuning seemed rather indifferent toward her.

However, Zhao Xuning was too reserved, so neither Xu Qingzhu nor Bai Weiwei could guess what she was thinking.

When Bai Weiwei was previously hospitalized, Xu Qingzhu had stayed in the room to take care of her, which was how she met Zhao Xuning.

Occasionally when she came to the hospital, Bai Weiwei would always instruct Zhao Xuning to take care of her, and gradually they became familiar.

Xu Qingzhu had indeed asked Zhao Xuning about Zhou Yi'an.

When Liang Shi played that voice message, Zhao Xuning was also present. After Liang Shi and Bai Weiwei left, Zhao Xuning specifically came back again to ask if she knew about the relationship between Liang Shi and Zhou Yi'an.

Xu Qingzhu did know some things. For example, Liang Shi had once said to Cheng Ran², "Screw Zhou Yi'an, even a toad³ wants to eat swan meat."

At that time, she didn't know what had happened and just looked up the name online, but couldn't find anything.

Gender concealment individuals regularly received injections, and only close people knew their gender. Applying to the national bureau to become a gender concealment individual provided state protection, ensuring no gender-related information would appear online.

Correspondingly, the application process to become a gender concealment individual was very complicated and required an expenditure of twenty million yuan.

So there weren't many gender concealment individuals in the country currently.

Gender concealment individuals were basically people who liked the same gender but feared public opinion attacks, so they chose to pay a high price to conceal their gender.

Zhou Yi'an was a typical example.

Once you became a gender concealment individual, the state would provide protection from public criticism.

After Xu Qingzhu told the truth, she asked Zhao Xuning, "Does Zhou Yi'an like Alphas? Or rather, does she like Liang Shi?"

Zhao Xuning paused and only said ambiguously, "The answer is what you think it is."

This also gave Xu Qingzhu a hint.

So Xu Qingzhu went to Liang Shi's hospital room.

She originally wanted to ask Liang Shi for help.

Although she didn't really want to speak up, her mother's phone call made her feel very conflicted, so she still went to see Liang Shi.

However, she heard some unpleasant content.

She heard the gist of what Mother Liang said.

She also heard the argument between mother and daughter, which made her emotions somewhat collapse.

But fortunately, she stopped herself at the last moment.

How could she rely on Liang Shi?

That was Liang Shi, after all.

Although... that didn't seem much like Liang Shi.

"Still thinking about Liang Shi?" Zhao Xuning's words brought back Xu Qingzhu's thoughts that had drifted far away. She shook herself and pressed her forehead with one hand. "No."

Then she changed her answer, "Yes."

"Did you confirm about her and Zhou Yi'an?" Zhao Xuning asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "I called her and got a general idea."

"That's good then." Zhao Xuning paused, pulled over a chair to sit down. Her white shirt was buttoned meticulously to the very top, her long hair casually tied up. She then slowly removed her glasses, revealing the beauty mark under the corner of her eye. The glasses frame was held between her fingers and turned around a few times casually. "You asked me to come here because you still want to understand about Liang Shi, right?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu didn't deny it. "You said before that Liang Shi showed symptoms of amnesia, right?"

"Yes, when she first woke up, she did have some symptoms of amnesia. I arranged for her to have a brain CT, which showed no problems. Her intelligence and physical condition hadn't declined." Zhao Xuning said, "But she's been very abnormal these past few days, as if... she suddenly became a different person."

"You've known her for a relatively long time. What do you think is the reason?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhao Xuning shook her head. "Although I know her, we're not close."

She didn't want to get involved with someone like Liang Shi.

Everyone in their small circle knew that Zhao Xuning and Liang Shi didn't get along.

That person had been arrogant and domineering since elementary school, marking territory, forming cliques, a pure little tyrant. Relying on having two older brothers and a wealthy, powerful family, the Liang family back then was even more formidable than now and could be counted among the prestigious families in Haicheng's upper-class circles.

So many years had passed, and the Liang family had also declined.

But Liang Shi's personality remained unchanged.

Even got worse.

Only... when she was kidnapped as a child, Liang Shi had also shown some strange symptoms.

Sometimes she would fall asleep in class, and when she suddenly woke up, she would say, "I'm not me, who am I?"

Very nonsensical.

But everyone privately thought it was because she had been kidnapped, so her mind was slightly unclear.

They heard that another little girl who was kidnapped fell into a coma for two months after returning and never spoke again.

At that time, Zhao Xuning didn't know that person was Xu Qingzhu.

And Zhao Xuning had always been cold by nature, with good grades, unwilling to interact with people. When she was in school, many people thought she was pretentious.

Moreover, she had a pretty good-looking face, and people would send her love letters every few days, which attracted a lot of jealousy.

Footnotes:

¹ Bai Weiwei (白薇薇): A supporting character who is a mutual friend of Xu Qingzhu and Zhao Xuning, working as a talent agent.

² Cheng Ran (程苒): One of the original Liang Shi's friends from her wealthy social circle.

³ Toad (癞蛤蟆): This is part of a Chinese idiom "癞蛤蟆想吃天鹅肉" (a toad wanting to eat swan meat), meaning someone with lowly status desiring something far above their station.

Chapter 18-2

Everyone begins their secondary gender differentiation¹ between ages 15-18.

Before age 15, no one knows what gender they will become.

Even so, many people still experience romantic stirrings before age 15.

In middle school, when a girl that Liang Shi liked gave Zhao Xuning a love letter, Liang Shi cornered Zhao Xuning after school with some people.

The two even arranged a fight.

That day both of them got injured, but Zhao Xuning came out ahead, and from then on Liang Shi never bothered Zhao Xuning again.

Zhao Xuning had always looked down on Liang Shi.

Or rather, she looked down on those second-generation rich kids who acted recklessly just because their families had money.

So Zhou Yi'an was also within her scope of dislike.

"But she is indeed very different from before," Zhao Xuning said honestly. "She suddenly became polite, modest, gentle, and even has some affinity."

After a moment of silence, Xu Qingzhu said, "Is there a possibility that this isn't Liang Shi?"

"I've considered that, but I checked all the surveillance footage since she was admitted to the hospital, and also verified her blood type and DNA. Everything proves that she is Liang Shi."

"What other reasons could cause her to change her personality overnight?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Have there been similar cases before?"

"There have been some before. Some were transferred to national secret organizations for research and were detained for decades. Others were later proven to have simply made heartfelt changes, but generally they were all stimulated by major events." Zhao Xuning paused. "Which type do you think she belongs to?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I'm not sure."

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu thought of something: "That day during my heat period, when she wanted to forcibly mark me, I pushed her hard and her head hit the wall with a particularly loud sound. Could it be related to that?"

"It's possible, but I checked and there's no blood clot compressing her nerves, so it doesn't seem like amnesia. But it could be caused by other factors." Zhao Xuning said, "I'll give her a full body examination tomorrow."

"Will she agree to it?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhao Xuning's hand, which had been turning her glasses, suddenly stopped, and she said firmly: "The current her will."

"But..." Zhao Xuning paused. "Isn't the current her good?"

"Very good, so good it's unbelievable," Xu Qingzhu said.

"So why bother about it?" Zhao Xuning said. "Whether she's a prodigal son who's reformed or had an awakening, as long as she's good enough now, isn't that fine? Sometimes people can't be too obsessed with answers."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled. "You're right."

After Zhao Xuning left, Xu Qingzhu lay in bed thinking.

After a long while, she sent Liang Shi a message: 【I lost my composure earlier, sorry.】

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Liang Shi only saw the text message when she woke up the next day. She replied: 【It's fine.】

Then she went downstairs to buy breakfast and brought it to the tenth floor to eat with Xu Qingzhu.

The two had a very quiet breakfast.

Liang Shi didn't think about bringing up divorce either.

She had already tried - sending divorce-related messages to Xu Qingzhu would be blocked by the system, and yesterday the system had briefly appeared to warn her not to do futile work anymore.

There were no shortcuts to conquest.

She gave up.

After breakfast, Liang Shi politely declined Zhao Xuning's suggestion for a full body examination, insisted on processing her own discharge, and asked Xu Qingzhu if she wanted to be discharged too.

Zhao Xuning happened to come by and said discharge was possible, but she would need to rest quietly at home and could only resume normal activities after careful observation for two days.

So Liang Shi processed her discharge procedures as well.

On the way home, Xu Qingzhu sat in the passenger seat without saying a word the entire journey, returning to that aloof appearance that kept strangers at bay.

Last night's vulnerability and distance seemed to have completely vanished.

The two were like strangers.

As the car was driving near Yunding Tower², Liang Shi's phone suddenly rang.

The soothing light music made Xu Qingzhu open her eyes. She looked at Liang Shi who was driving. "Pull over or should I hang up for you?"

Liang Shi said: "Check who it is first."

She didn't dare to suddenly let Xu Qingzhu answer.

The original owner's phone was like a ticking time bomb - you never knew when it would explode.

She was already nervous answering it herself, let alone having Xu Qingzhu answer.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at it - it was Xu Qingya.

Only then did she answer and put it on speaker.

Xu Qingya said on the phone: "Sister Liang Shi, what are you doing? Let's discuss something."

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu, who just mouthed: "Drive properly."

Liang Shi coughed lightly and tried to sound normal: "What is it?"

"The hotel is too lonely," Xu Qingya said. "Can I stay at your house for a few days?"

Xu Qingzhu decisively refused: "No."

"Ah? My sister is there too?" Xu Qingya was somewhat annoyed, then said: "I'm asking Sister Liang Shi, not you."

"I have the final say," Xu Qingzhu said.

Xu Qingya snorted coldly: "I'm going anyway. I'm already at your front door. Come back quickly."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Liang Shi had no choice but to say: "Then wait a moment. Your sister and I will be there soon."

After hanging up, Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll handle my sister's affairs, you don't need to worry. When we get back, I'll move to the easternmost room on the first floor and pay you rent at market rate. My father is in poor health and the company has some problems now, so I can't divorce you temporarily. But when the right time comes, we'll go get divorced, okay?"

Before Liang Shi could respond, Xu Qingzhu continued: "During this time, I hope you can act the same as before in front of my family members. Act if you can."

Liang Shi: "....."

Footnotes:

¹ Secondary gender differentiation (分化): In ABO dynamics, this refers to when individuals develop their Alpha, Beta, or Omega characteristics during puberty.

² Yunding Tower (雲頂大廈): A high-end residential building where Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu live.

